



which drove him to look at more products and innovations.

The turning point in his life came in 1995, when a trader came to Wankaner looking for a potter who could provide clay water-filters. The trader had to deliver this order to a client in Nairobi, Kenya. Mansukhlal was shown the design and was told to deliver the water filter in a month's time. He created the terracotta filter with a ceramic candle for filtration within eight days. Looking at the quality of the output and design, the exporter immediately ordered 500 pieces at a price of Rs 200 each, which was twice the earlier rate.

In 2001, when the earthquake in Gujarat destroyed homes and people's belongings, Mansukhlal de-

**MANSUKHLAL WITH
HIS CLAY PRODUCTS**

THE REFRIGERATOR SERVES TWO PURPOSES: COOLING POTABLE WATER AND ACTING AS A COLD STORAGE SPACE.

developed a hand press machine with a capacity to produce 700 earthen pans a day, up from 100 handmade pans that most potters were making. Mansukhlal mechanised the production to increase output. He quit his job at the tile factory and started making terracotta tawas, called tavdis in Gujarati. The response he got from nearby markets was phenomenal,

cided to make a poor man's fridge and water-filter that would be cheap and yet meet the requirements. This eco-friendly refrigerator that he has developed is made of clay. Mansukhlal finessed the Mitticool Refrigerator after the Gujarat Grassroots Innovation Augmentation Network (GIAN), Ahmedabad, helped him with design inputs. The outcome is a

refrigerator with a capacity of 50 litres. The upper portion of this fridge can store about 20 litres of water, while the section below the water tank has separate space to store fruits, vegetables and milk.

The water in the tank keeps the temperature lower in the cabinet so that vegetables and fruits stay fresh for almost five days, while milk can be preserved for three days. He recalls: "After the earthquake in Gujarat, most potters lost all their wares like I did. While rebuilding my business, I decided to move away from traditional clay pots and tawas and make something different." Mansukhlal's clay refrigerator serves the dual purpose of cooling potable water and acting as a cold storage space. Thanks to the water tank atop the refrigerator, the temperature inside is at least 10-15 degrees lower than the ambient air temperature.

Armed with the success of the Mitticool refrigerator, Mansukhlal started experimenting with non-stick tawas and water coolers. For instance, the clay water cooler comes with a 0.9 micron candle inside the water storage pot to filter water. Clay is a magical ingredient, Mansukhlal believes, because it's environment-friendly, and also because these natural products don't need electricity to function.

The hottest selling item today from Mansukhlal's Mitticool range is the non-stick tawa, which is substantially cheaper than other non-stick utensils. It is again made out of clay and has a Teflon coating, no less competition for its metallic counterparts. Unlike other non-stick cookware available in market, this one is priced affordably at Rs 50. This compelling innovator hasn't stopped at that and is now working on a pressure cooker made of clay. For this enterprising man, earthy values have scored. ■

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